THE ATHLETE CIRCLE

THE PLAYBOOK

Build Your Athlete Circle

A Decision Playbook for the Modern Athlete

5 modules · 6 bonuses · worksheets & scorecards

Featuring the Connor Barry case study

THE ATHLETE CIRCLE

athletecircle.ai

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OUR PROMISE TO YOUR FAMILY

*Talent opens doors.
The right Circle determines what happens next.*

Clarity — We replace confusion with structured frameworks and clear next steps.

Protection — We help you see irreversible decisions before they happen — not after.

Alignment — We work for the athlete and the family. Never for the deal.

That is the promise behind every page that follows.

START HERE

Foreword: The Decision Layer

There has never been a more lucrative — or more complicated — moment to be a young athlete. NIL did not just change how athletes earn. It changed who is calling, what they are offering, and how early the stakes get real. By the time a junior in high school posts a recruiting reel, agents, brand managers, financial people, and self-appointed advisors are already messaging. By the time a freshman steps on a college campus, contracts are crossing the table. And almost none of those athletes — or their families — are handed a structure for sorting signal from noise.

This is the gap The Athlete Circle exists to close. The path between talent and a long-term career is no longer a straight line of practices and games. It is a series of decisions — about agents, about brands, about contracts, about money, about who is allowed close enough to influence any of it. Most athletes are not bad at the game. They are undertrained for the decisions around the game.

That is what this playbook is. Not motivation. Not theory. A working decision layer — frameworks you can apply on the next phone call, scorecards you can fill out the next time an agent reaches out, scripts you can use the next time a brand offers a deal. Built so a family can run it together: clear enough for a 17-year-old, rigorous enough for the parent signing next to them.

> *Talent opens doors. The right Circle determines what happens next.*

One note on how this book speaks. It addresses the athlete and the parent as a unit, because that is how these decisions actually get made — and because several of them legally require an adult. Each module closes with a **Parent lane / Athlete lane** box that splits the work. Read those together. Most family friction around NIL is not disagreement about the right answer; it is confusion about who is supposed to decide.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to Use This Playbook

Read it once front-to-back, then keep it open as a reference. Each module stands alone — when an agent calls, reread Module 2. When a brand offers a deal, pull up Module 3. When a contract lands in your inbox, Module 4 gets you through it.

The modules

1. **The Circle Framework** — read this first. It is the operating system everything else hangs from.
2. **Agent Evaluation** — read before signing with anyone or upgrading representation.
3. **NIL Deal Evaluation** — read before responding to any brand, sponsor, or NIL offer.
4. **Contract Red Flags** — read every time a contract is in front of you. Then read it again.
5. **The Athlete Operating System** — read once a quarter to keep decisions aligned with your long-term direction.

The bonus pack

- **Bonus 1 — The Outreach Playbook** (Sandler-based brand outreach, agent-supervised)
- **Bonus 2 — Your 30-Day Action Plan** (week-by-week implementation)
- **Bonus 3 — The Connor Barry Case Study** (the pilot athlete, updated July 2026)
- **Bonus 4 — The Family Conversation, Extended** (the facilitator's edition)
- **Bonus 5 — Quick-Reference Cards** (the four pages to print and pin up)
- **Bonus 6 — Your Strategy Call + Quarterly Updates** (what is included and how to redeem)

IMPORTANT — READ THIS BEFORE GOING FURTHER. This playbook is educational. It is not legal advice, financial advice, or representation. The frameworks here help you ask better questions and identify risk earlier — they do not replace a licensed attorney, a registered financial advisor, or a properly vetted agent. Before signing any agreement, get qualified professional review. Use this material to know what you are looking at; use professionals to make the call.

ORIENTATION

Where You Are Right Now

The modules do not all fire at once. Find your row, start with the modules marked for your stage, then work through the rest.

YOUR STAGE	WHAT'S ALREADY TRUE	START WITH
High school, 9th–10th grade	Your content is public and permanent. The first "advisors" are 1–2 years away.	Module 1, then Module 5
High school, junior or senior	Recruiting contact is live. Handlers and unofficial mentors are showing up.	Module 1, then Module 2
College, no NIL income yet	School compliance and the NIL Go reporting rules apply to you now.	Module 3, then Module 1
College, earning NIL income	Tax exposure, reporting duties, and contract terms are live today.	Module 4, then Module 3
Any stage, already signed something	Your leverage lives in what you sign next. Audit what this one locked out.	Module 4, then Module 2

Wherever you start, run the **30-Day Action Plan** (Bonus 2) in your first month. It sequences the first pass through everything.

MODULE 1

The Circle Framework

Five roles. Right people. Real boundaries.

MODULE 1

Why the Circle Exists

The single most important predictor of how a young athlete's career and finances unfold is not talent. It is the quality of the people standing closest to the decisions. Coaches matter for performance. The Circle matters for everything that determines how performance gets converted into a life.

In its simplest form, the Circle is five trusted advisory roles — **Lawyer, Agent, Financial Advisor, Trainer, and Mentor** — operating with clear scope, aligned incentives, and explicit boundaries. That is the picture. The principle behind it matters more: every meaningful decision an athlete makes flows through people, and those people either filter it well or filter it badly. There is no third option.

This module operationalizes the Circle: what each role does, what each role does *not* do, when each becomes relevant, and the failure patterns that show up without structure. Read it once. Then complete the worksheet at the end — together.

The Circle Map

Picture five supports around the athlete. Each has a defined function and a defined limit. None substitutes for another. The common family error is asking one role to do two — the agent who "also handles money," the family member who "also handles legal." It feels efficient. It compounds risk.

ROLE	PRIMARY FUNCTION	WHEN THEY ENTER	COMMON MISUSE
Lawyer	Contract review, structural protection, compliance	First sign of any written agreement — HS or earlier	Asked for business or career advice outside legal scope
Agent	Sourcing opportunities, negotiation, market positioning	Once NIL offers or a pro path becomes real	Asked to provide financial or legal counsel
Financial Advisor	Budgeting, tax structure, investment, long-term wealth	First dollar of NIL income	Selling products dressed as advice
Trainer	Performance, conditioning, recovery	HS varsity onward	Asked to make career or representation decisions
Mentor	Perspective, character, decision support	Throughout — the earlier the better	Confused with a guru or paid coach

Each role has weight only when it stays in lane. Mixing them creates conflict of interest. Conflict of interest creates bad decisions. And bad decisions, in NIL and the early professional years, are often irreversible.

Each role in depth

LAWYER — THE STRUCTURAL PROTECTOR

Their job is to read what is in front of you with the discipline of someone whose entire career is built on catching what most people miss. **A good lawyer:** reviews every agreement before signature; identifies onerous clauses (perpetual rights, exclusivity, morality, indemnity); translates legal language into clear recommendations; negotiates amendments; builds the paper trail that protects you in a dispute. **A good lawyer does not:** tell you which deal is best, manage your money, or broker deals for a cut — that last one is a conflict of interest.

When to add: the day a third party asks you to sign anything — recruiting service agreements, NIL feelers, agent letters of intent, even some camp waivers. If people are sliding into the DMs with “opportunities,” it is already time.

AGENT — THE MARKET ARM

They live in your industry’s deal flow every day; that is their value. **A good agent:** sources real opportunities, negotiates compensation and exclusivity, positions you for the next 12–36 months, coordinates with your lawyer *before* asking you to sign, and says no on your behalf. **A good agent does not:** pressure you to sign without legal review, steer you into affiliated financial products, bring deals that conflict with your stated values, or operate without a transparent fee structure.

When to add: when real money is on the table and you are losing more value managing it yourself than the commission costs — concretely, when serious offers approach five figures, or a high-stakes window (portal, combine, draft) is about to compress into 60–90 days. Module 2 is the full evaluation.

FINANCIAL ADVISOR — THE MONEY INFRASTRUCTURE

A good financial advisor: operates under a fiduciary standard (not just “suitability” — there is a legal difference), sets up entity structure for NIL income, plans for taxes before income hits, builds the long-term plan, and coordinates with your CPA and lawyer. **A good financial advisor does not:** sell products you cannot explain back in plain English, push illiquid investments at 20, hide commission compensation, or promise returns — anyone who does is lying or unqualified.

> **Watch the title.** “Financial advisor” is not a regulated term — anyone can use it. Look for: CFP® certification, fiduciary status *in writing*, and a transparent fee model (flat, hourly, or AUM). Commission-driven “advisors” are functionally salespeople.

TRAINER — THE PERFORMANCE ARM

Inside a college program you have official staff; outside it, a private trainer or skills coach. **A good trainer** builds programs around your sport and body, coordinates with school staff rather than against them, and stays in the performance lane. **A good trainer does not** recommend supplements without compliance coordination, become an unofficial manager or agent, or charge based on your NIL earnings.

MENTOR — THE CHARACTER ANCHOR

Not technical. Perspective, experience, and honesty that paid advisors often cannot deliver — partly because mentors are typically not compensated, so you can trust the advice. They come from family, faith community, older athletes two-to-five years ahead, earlier coaches, and business leaders who agree to walk with you. The best mentors knew you before the spotlight. That memory is part of what protects you.

Sequencing — when each role joins

STAGE	MENTOR	TRAINER	LAWYER	AGENT	FIN. ADVISOR
Pre-HS / 8th–9th	Add	Add	—	—	—
HS varsity / 10th–11th	✓	✓	Add early	—	—
HS senior / NIL active	✓	✓	✓	Case-by-case	Add
College freshman	✓	✓	✓	If NIL volume	✓
College / serious NIL	✓	✓	✓	Required	✓
Pre-pro / draft cycle	✓	✓	✓	Required	✓

Five common Circle failures

1. **One person playing two roles.** Each combination creates a conflict of interest that bends decisions away from the athlete's long-term outcome. Even with pure intentions, the structure produces drift.
2. **No defined scope.** When boundaries are not written down, every decision invites everyone to weigh in on everything. That is not a Circle — that is a committee, and committees protect no one.
3. **Hiring on charisma instead of fit.** Polish is not credentials. Check the structure before the personality.
4. **Adding people too fast.** Families assemble the whole Circle in a week — usually right after a big offer, which is exactly when pressure compresses judgment. Build the Circle before you need it.
5. **Refusing to fire.** The wrong agent costs more than the awkward conversation. The Circle is a working tool, not a loyalty oath.

Worksheet — your Circle audit

Fill this in together, with honesty. The point is diagnosis, not optics. Blank rows are where you build from.

ROLE	CURRENTLY FILLED BY	HOW WE MET / YEARS KNOWN	ALIGNED INCENTIVE? (Y/N)	ACTION
Lawyer				Keep / Replace / Add
Agent				Keep / Replace / Add
Financial Advisor				Keep / Replace / Add
Trainer				Keep / Replace / Add
Mentor				Keep / Replace / Add

Any "No" under aligned incentive is the role to fix first. Any empty row is the gap to fill next.

PARENT LANE / ATHLETE LANE

Parent or guardian — You run the audit and own the vetting — references, engagement letters, fee structures, and the annual review. Start with the lawyer; every other role gets easier once that one is filled.

Athlete — You own the disclosure. The Circle can only protect you from people it knows exist. Who is in the DMs, who is offering what, who has been coming around — say it out loud, every time.

MODULE 1 TAKEAWAY

Five roles. Five clearly bounded jobs. Sequenced as you grow. **No role doubles up. No role gets added under pressure.** The Circle is what makes every other module in this playbook work — because frameworks only matter if the right people are running them with you.

MODULE 2

The Agent Evaluation Playbook

How to choose, vet, hire — and when needed, fire — your representation.

MODULE 2

How Agents Actually Make Money

Before you can evaluate an agent, you have to understand how they earn. Compensation drives behavior. The math is simple but rarely explained to the people who need it most.

SPORT / TIER	TYPICAL COMMISSION	NOTES
NIL deals (college)	10–20%	Highly variable; some agencies bundle into a flat retainer
NFL playing contracts	3% (regulated max)	NFLPA caps player-contract commissions
NFL marketing / endorsement	10–20%	Not capped — this is where serious money is made
NBA playing contracts	4% (regulated max)	NBPA-capped
NBA marketing / endorsement	10–20%	Not capped
MLB playing contracts	4–5% (custom)	By agreement
Olympic / individual sport	15–30%	Higher because lower base income

Commission ranges as of July 2026. Verify current association caps before negotiating.

Two things to hold onto. Commission is paid out of your earnings, not on top — a 15% deal on a $20K NIL contract puts $3K with the agent and $17K, gross, with you. And marketing commission is where most agent money is made: the agent often earns more on a $200K endorsement than on the playing contract that justified hiring them.

Marketing-side conflicts of interest. Some agencies route brand deals through affiliated production companies or sub-agencies — and take a cut on both sides. Always ask: *"Is anyone on your team or affiliated with your firm being paid by the brand on this deal, in addition to the commission you charge me?"* Anything other than a clean no goes in writing.

What a good agent actually does

Agents get credit for “getting the deal.” That is the visible part. The work that separates great agents from average ones is mostly invisible:

- Says **no** to deals you never see — blocking pitches that would damage your brand or value
- Negotiates deliverables you did not think to ask for — fewer posts, longer timelines, narrower exclusivity
- Manages timing — pushes back on $25K today if $200K is two months away under the same exclusivity
- Coordinates with your lawyer **before** sending a contract for signature
- Knows what comparable athletes are getting, so you never accept below market
- Handles the awkward conversations — payment delays, deliverable disputes, brand conflicts
- Sends monthly statements showing all activity, deals, and pending opportunities

> *An agent’s true value is not the deal they bring you — it is the deals they keep you from signing.*

The eight questions to ask before signing

Not ice-breakers — diagnostics. Ask them in order, and watch how they answer.

1. **What is your full commission structure** across NIL, endorsement, and playing contracts? Get it in writing.
2. **Walk me through the last three deals you closed** for athletes at my level. What did you negotiate up from the first offer?
3. **Who else on your team would touch my account?** What is the difference between you and them?
4. **What happens if I want to leave in six months?** What is the exit clause?
5. **Are you certified** by the relevant players association and licensed under the Uniform Athlete Agents Act in my state?
6. **Do you ever take compensation from brands directly**, in addition to my commission?
7. **Tell me about a deal you turned down** for an athlete because it was not right.
8. **What am I honestly worth in NIL today** — and what would have to change for that number to grow?

How to read the answers. Strong agents answer #1 with specifics, not ranges. #2 with real, recent numbers. #4 without flinching. #6 with a clean no or a clean disclosure. #7 with confidence — agents who never turn down deals are chasing volume, not protecting you. #8 with honest assessment, not flattery.

Red flags in agent contracts

If any of these appear, do not sign until they are removed or materially modified:

- **Lifetime or perpetual representation.** Industry standard is 1–2 years with 30-day termination notice.
- **Unlimited tail clauses** — claiming a cut of deals you sign after leaving. Limit to 60–90 days, on deals already in active written negotiation.
- **Sweeping IP grants** — rights to your name and likeness in their promotional materials in perpetuity. Strike or limit.
- **Tied-services clauses** — requiring you to use their preferred lawyer, tax advisor, or manager. That is the conflict-of-interest pattern. Strike.
- **Universal-deals clauses** — claiming 100% of any deal that "first comes in" during representation. Limit the scope.
- **No reporting requirements.** Require monthly written statements.
- **One-sided assignability.** You want the right to follow your agent — or stay with the firm — at your choice, not theirs.

Negotiating the agreement

Most athletes accept the first draft. That is a mistake — standard agreements are drafted in the agent's favor, and reasonable changes are commonly accepted when asked: commission down from 20% toward 15% (10% is achievable for higher-value athletes); initial term capped at 1 year with renewal; 30-day no-cause termination after the first 90 days; monthly reporting; a limited tail; carve-outs for family-introduced and community deals; and a clause requiring coordination with **your** independent counsel before any execution.

> **Always have your own lawyer review the agent agreement.** Hiring an agent means signing a contract drafted by a lawyer. The agent's contract is the first place your Circle's discipline shows up — skip this step and you have broken the framework before deal one.

When and how to fire your agent

Most athletes wait too long. The signs are usually present months before the break: slow responses on real opportunities; a pipeline that stops growing after 60 days; deal quality trending down; calls only when there is a deal to close; conflicts you did not know about; you chasing them more than they chase the market. **Two or more of those — it is time.**

1. Have your lawyer review the termination clause and reporting requirements.
2. Document the pattern in writing, for yourself, with dates.
3. Your lawyer sends the formal termination notice per the contract — not a text from you.
4. Identify open deals and where tail-clause commission might apply.
5. Request a final accounting in both directions.
6. Move on. The lawyer handles the back-and-forth.

PARENT LANE / ATHLETE LANE

Parent or guardian — You run the commercial half of every agent meeting — money and exit questions land differently coming from a parent — and you own “we will get back to you.” No agreement is signed without independent legal review.

Athlete — You own the fit and the working relationship. You will talk with this person more than most of your coaches. If it feels off in the first meeting, it does not improve after the signature.

MODULE 2 TAKEAWAY

The right agent is a multiplier; the wrong one is a tax. **Vet on structure, not charisma.** Get the contract reviewed by your own lawyer. Negotiate commission, term, and reporting. And do not stay attached to a relationship that has stopped producing — your agent works for you, not the other way around.

MODULE 3

The NIL Deal Evaluation Framework

Every offer through five filters. No exceptions.

NIL in 2026 — The Rules Have Changed

NIL began in 2021, when college athletes won the right to earn from their name, image, and likeness. But the system you are operating in today was reshaped by the **House v. NCAA settlement**, approved in June 2025 and effective July 1, 2025. If your understanding of NIL predates that, it is out of date. Here is the current landscape.

The three streams of athlete compensation

1. **Revenue sharing (school pays you).** Schools that opt into the settlement can now pay athletes directly, under an annual per-school cap that started at roughly $20.5 million and rises each year. How a school allocates it across sports and athletes is largely its call — which makes your revenue-share agreement a *contract to be read*, not a scholarship to be thanked for. Term length, transfer provisions, and buyout language all materially change its value.
2. **Third-party NIL (brands pay you).** Brand deals, endorsements, and collectives — the subject of this module. These now run through a reporting and review system (below).
3. **Traditional benefits.** Scholarships and education-related support continue alongside both.

The oversight layer — what you must do now

The **College Sports Commission (CSC)** is the enforcement arm of the post-settlement system, and **NIL Go** is its clearinghouse. The operating rules that matter to you:

- **Report at $600.** Third-party NIL agreements of $600 or more must be reported through NIL Go — within days of execution, before the work happens. Your school's compliance office will have the exact workflow.
- **Deals are actually reviewed.** Larger deals are screened for a *valid business purpose* and *compensation in a reasonable range* for what is actually being delivered. This is a real review, not a rubber stamp — the CSC has rejected a meaningful number of submitted deals. Pay-for-play dressed up as NIL does not clear.
- **Smaller deals move faster.** As of July 2026, most deals between $600 and $15,000 skip the full compensation-range review — unless your aggregate deal volume for the academic year passes $50,000. Thresholds move; confirm the current ones with compliance before you rely on them.
- **A rejected deal is an eligibility problem.** Money promised on a deal that later fails review may never arrive — and taking it anyway puts your eligibility at risk. This is why nothing gets spent, promised, or posted before a deal clears.
- **Prohibited categories still apply.** Gambling and sportsbooks, alcohol during eligibility, tobacco and vape, banned substances, adult entertainment — plus whatever your state law, conference, and school add. Check current school policy every season.

The practical translation: every real NIL deal now has a compliance step baked in. A brand that resists putting terms in writing, discourages you from reporting, or wants to move faster than the review allows is not a partner — it is a liability. Rules in this section are current as of **July 2026**; the quarterly update tracks changes.

The 5-question filter

Run every offer through these five questions, in order. Stop at the first one that fails. The order is the protection — it keeps you from talking yourself into a deal you already failed on question one.

1 — Does this brand align with my values and long-term identity? A deal that pays now but conflicts with who you are becoming costs more in long-term brand value than it pays in cash. The hard test: would you be comfortable with this partnership as the lead line of your profile in five years? In ten? For a faith-anchored athlete this filter has extra dimensions — a brand whose voice openly conflicts with your identity may pay well and still be wrong. Money is replaceable; alignment is what makes a brand cohere over a career.

2 — What am I actually committing to? Read the deliverables out loud. Then the exclusivity terms. How many posts, stories, appearances — over what period? Can the brand reuse the content forever, or is the license time-limited? What is required outside social — events, shoots, rep work? The volume of work hiding behind "one Instagram post" is the most common reason athletes feel cheated by NIL. The post is rarely just a post.

3 — Is the price right? There is a working market rate based on audience, engagement, sport, and visibility. The table below is the starting point. A brand offering a fraction of the low end is counting on you not knowing it — and remember, the compensation-range review means a wildly *above*-market number can also fail clearance.

4 — What does this deal lock me out of? The most under-asked question in NIL. If the deal is category-exclusive, what is the size of the prize you are declining for the next 12 months? Is there a competitor list, and are likely future partners on it? Does a right of first refusal hang over your renewals?

5 — Am I structurally ready? Compliance notified and the NIL Go report filed? Entity and bank account in place? Tax reserve funded? Lawyer reviewed? Agent signed off? Even a good deal hurts you if the infrastructure is not there.

> *Most athletes lose more value to the wrong deals they signed than to the right deals they walked away from.*

Market rate reference

AUDIENCE TIER	SINGLE POST	4-WEEK PACKAGE	ANNUAL AMBASSADOR
Under 10K	$200 – $1K	$1K – $5K	$5K – $15K
10K – 50K	$1K – $5K	$5K – $20K	$15K – $50K
50K – 250K	$5K – $15K	$20K – $75K	$50K – $200K
250K+	$15K+	$75K+	$200K+

Mid-market estimates, current as of Q3 2026 (July 2026). Sport, position visibility (QBs above most positions), engagement rate, and brand budget all shift the range. NIL pricing moves quickly — check the current quarterly update before relying on these in a negotiation.

Deal types — pick the right structure

TYPE	HOW YOU GET PAID	PROS	CONS
Endorsement (flat fee)	Lump sum or tranches for fixed deliverables	Predictable. Cleaner taxes. Easy to value.	Caps upside if the campaign overperforms.
Affiliate / commission	% of sales via your code or link	Unlimited upside with real volume.	Can pay zero. Tracking can be opaque.
Equity / token	Stock or tokens, often vesting	Ownership. Multi-year alignment.	Most are worth zero. Vesting + tax timing is complex — get advice first.
Ambassadorship	Multi-month retainer	Stable income. Real partnership.	More work than expected. Exclusivity common.

Tax structure 101

Disclaimer: this section is general education only, not tax advice. NIL income creates real obligations — build the actual plan with a CPA who has worked with college athletes.

- **It is self-employment income** (1099, not W-2) — you owe income tax *and* ~15.3% self-employment tax. Revenue-share payments from your school are also taxable income; confirm treatment with your CPA.
- **Quarterly estimated payments.** Owe more than ~$1,000 for the year and the IRS expects quarterly payments (Apr, Jun, Sep, Jan). Missing them creates penalties.
- **LLC vs. sole prop.** Most athlete-specialized CPAs recommend a single-member LLC — EIN, business bank account, income routed through it. S-Corp at higher income levels is a CPA call.
- **Multi-state exposure.** Many states tax NIL income earned in-state even if you do not live there. National athletes get multi-state filings.
- **Deductions.** Equipment, training, travel for brand events, agent fees — potentially deductible. Track everything.
- **Reserve immediately.** From every NIL dollar: 25–35% to a tax reserve on receipt. If your CPA says less, follow their number — never below 20%.

The Connor Barry test case

To make this concrete, walk a hypothetical offer through the filters the way Connor Barry's team would. **The pitch, via Instagram DM:** $8,000 for four posts over two months, sports-drink category exclusivity, perpetual content rights. The brand also operates in markets that sponsor sports gambling content.

1. **Values and identity** — the gambling-adjacent activity is a hard flag. Connor's faith-anchored brand and the prohibited-category rules make this a non-starter regardless of price. **Stop here.**
2. **If filter 1 had passed — commitments:** "four posts" plus perpetual content rights is not four posts. It is a permanent asset transfer. Negotiate to a 12–18 month license.
3. **Price:** $8K for four posts at a Big Ten QB's tier is below market — the range suggests $12K–$25K. The perpetual rights make the price worse, not better.
4. **Lockouts:** two months of sports-drink exclusivity is reasonable only if nothing bigger is in the pipeline. If a major brand is a likely future partner, confirm before closing that door.
5. **Structural readiness:** NIL Go report, compliance, lawyer, agent, tax reserve — normal routing, no blockers. But filter 1 already killed it. **Decision: pass.**

Worksheet — NIL deal evaluation

One of these for every offer. If you cannot fill in the blanks, that is a signal to slow down — not a signal the framework does not apply.

Brand name + parent company: ______________________________

Total compensation: ______________________________

Deliverables (count + format): ______________________________

Term length / exclusivity scope + duration: ______________________________

Content license duration: ______________________________

Filter 1 — values aligned? Y/N + why: ______________________________

Filter 2 — total work commitment realistic? Y/N: ______________________________

Filter 3 — price within market range? Y/N: ______________________________

Filter 4 — what gets locked out, and what is that worth: ______________________________

Filter 5 — NIL Go report, compliance, entity, lawyer, agent, tax? Y/N: ______________________________

Final decision — ACCEPT / NEGOTIATE / DECLINE: ______________________________

PARENT LANE / ATHLETE LANE

Parent or guardian — You own filters 3, 4, and 5 — market rate, lockouts, and structure — plus the 48-hour clock: "Send it in writing; we respond within 48 hours." You are the one in the room who is not excited.

Athlete — You own filters 1 and 2 — nobody else can say what you want to be known for, and nobody else has to do the work written into the deliverables.

MODULE 3 TAKEAWAY

Three compensation streams, one review system, five filters — **in order, stopping at the first failure.** The market has a price; learn it before you negotiate. Report early, clear first, spend later. And run the worksheet on every offer, especially the ones that look too good to refuse — those are where this framework saves the most.

MODULE 4

Contract Red Flags & Decision Playbooks

Twelve clauses to know cold. One question to never answer.

MODULE 4

How to Read a Contract Without a Law Degree

You will not replace professional legal review with this module — that is what your lawyer is for. But you can absolutely get to the point where you scan a contract, flag what needs real review, and recognize the language patterns that mean *slow down*. That is the goal.

1. **Always read it yourself.** Twice, out loud, before you talk to your lawyer. You catch things on the second pass.
2. **If you do not understand it, you cannot sign it.** A clause you cannot explain, plus a counterparty rushing past your question, is a flag. The contract binds you regardless of what you did not understand.
3. **Markup beats silence.** When in doubt, mark it up and ask. Lawyers expect questions. Brands expect questions. Anyone who does not is the wrong partner.

The 12 red-flag clauses

#	CLAUSE	WATCH FOR	THE FIX
1	**Perpetual rights**	“in perpetuity,” “indefinite,” “forever”	License period of 12–24 months, optional renewal
2	**Unbounded exclusivity**	“exclusive worldwide,” “any related category”	Narrow definition, named competitors, time limit
3	**Morality clauses**	“objectionable conduct,” “sole discretion”	Objective standards — conviction, documented breach
4	**Indemnification**	“indemnify,” “hold harmless,” attorney fees	Cap at total compensation; make it mutual
5	**Tied services**	Required use of their photographer, advisor, manager	Strike. You choose your providers
6	**First refusal rights**	“right of first refusal / first negotiation”	30-day window; must match a written competing offer
7	**No approval rights**	Silence on content approval	Pre-publication approval, 24–72 hr response window
8	**Auto-renewal**	“shall automatically renew unless…”	Manual renewal, or 60–90 day advance written notice
9	**One-way assignability**	Brand can assign to a third party without consent	Your written consent, or affiliates only
10	**Distant forum**	Disputes governed and litigated far from you	Home-state law, or neutral arbitration
11	**Oversized damages**	Penalties far exceeding deal value	Cap at contract value; notice + cure period first
12	**Vague deliverables**	“reasonable amount,” “as needed,” “mutually agreed”	Itemize: counts, platforms, dates, approval flow

Each clause above has specific negotiation language your lawyer can adapt — bring the list to the review call.

The 7-gate decision tree — should I sign today?

Run the contract through these gates in order. Any "no" means stop and resolve — not sign and hope.

1. Has my lawyer reviewed and approved?
2. Has my agent (if applicable) signed off?
3. Did it pass the 5-question filter from Module 3?
4. Are all 12 red-flag clauses checked — and none present unmodified?
5. Has school compliance been notified and the NIL Go report planned or filed?
6. Do I have the entity, bank account, and tax reserve ready?
7. Am I signing from alignment — or from pressure?

All seven clear: sign with confidence. Anything unclear: ask. The right move is never to sign and hope.

The four things you never agree to verbally

Even said casually on a phone call, these can be argued as binding in a dispute:

1. "I'll wear it on game day." What you wear depends on the deal — and you have not seen the deal.
2. "I'll post X times." Frequency is negotiation, not conversation.
3. "That sounds good — let's do it." Construable as agreement before terms exist. Say instead: "Let me get my team on this."
4. "I won't sign with anyone else in the meantime." Verbal exclusivity has been litigated. Never.

Your default response to any verbal pressure: "My team handles all commercial conversations. Can you send the proposed terms in writing? I'll get on a call with my agent and lawyer to walk through it." That is the whole script. The athletes who get burned are the ones trying to be polite. Be friendly. Don't be casual. **Under 18?** Shorter still: "I'm not 18. My parents handle all of this. Please send it to them in writing."

Cautionary tales (anonymized)

Composites of real situations from NIL's first years. Names removed; lessons intact.

THE FREE PRODUCT THAT WASN'T

A freshman accepts $2K plus free product from a small brand. Six months later she is on nationwide billboards she never specifically consented to — the contract granted perpetual advertising rights. Front-end legal review would have caught it. She had no lawyer, because the deal was "too small to bother." **No deal is too small to read.**

THE EXCLUSIVITY THAT KILLED A REAL OPPORTUNITY

A QB signs a $5K deal with a small energy drink. Three months later a major sports-drink brand offers $200K — and he is blocked, because "sports beverages" was defined to include energy drinks. The small deal cost forty times its value. **The category should have been narrowed at signing.**

THE MORALITY CLAUSE AND THE RUMOR

An athlete posts a normal photo with friends; a blog twists the context. Within 48 hours, two of three brand partners invoke morality clauses — all "sole discretion," no objective standards. No recourse. **He learned the clause too late.**

THE VERBAL YES

On a casual call an athlete says, "Yeah, that sounds great, let's do it," then signs with a competitor two weeks later. The brand sues, claiming the verbal commitment was binding. Settled out of court — for more than the original offer was worth. **Don't say yes. Ever. Say: "my team will look at it."**

PARENT LANE / ATHLETE LANE

Parent or guardian — You own the signature and the legal relationship. Nothing reaches your lawyer late — the relationship exists before the first contract arrives. And every gate in the decision tree is yours to enforce when excitement is running high.

Athlete — You own what comes out of your mouth. Every verbal commitment happens in a moment, usually alone. Memorize the script until it is boring — boring is what safe sounds like.

MODULE 4 TAKEAWAY

Twelve clauses to check. Seven gates before signing. Four things you never say. **Master those three lists and you eliminate roughly 80% of the avoidable NIL mistakes.** The remaining 20% requires a real lawyer — which is why Module 1 makes that role non-negotiable.

MODULE 5

The Strategic Athlete Operating System

Performance is what you do. The system is who you become.

MODULE 5

From Decisions to a System

The first four modules are frameworks for individual decisions — who is in your Circle, how to evaluate an agent, how to filter deals, how to read contracts. Useful, but reactive. Each one fires when something happens *to* you.

Module 5 inverts that. The athletes who compound their advantages are not the ones who handle each decision brilliantly in the moment. They are the ones operating from a system that already made most of the small decisions before the moment arrived. That is the Athlete Operating System: the standing orders you are running on before the next call comes in.

> *An athlete with a system makes a thousand small decisions in advance. An athlete without one makes them all under pressure.*

The five pillars — standing orders

PILLAR 1 — ELIGIBILITY

- Compliance officer's name and direct contact saved in both of your phones
- Every NIL deal disclosed proactively — and reported through NIL Go on time
- Nothing labeled "agent agreement" or "representation" signed before legal review
- All prohibited categories avoided; school NIL policy re-read at the start of every season — it changes

PILLAR 2 — CIRCLE

- Five roles, quarterly review of who is producing
- Two roles held by one person triggers a Circle audit within 30 days
- Mentor connection monthly — not optional
- Annual legal review of every active agreement, including the ones you "know are fine"

PILLAR 3 — BRAND

- Your brand promise written in three sentences; read before any major content decision
- No posts about money, contracts, or other athletes' deals
- 1–2 intentional posts per week in season; quality over volume
- Highlight reel and one-page profile updated quarterly; every new partner reviewed against the promise before deal stage

PILLAR 4 — FINANCE

- 30% of every NIL dollar to the tax-reserve account on receipt — automatic
- 10% of every NIL dollar to long-term investing — automatic
- Quarterly CPA meeting in season; annual full review
- No major purchase without a 72-hour cooling-off period and a Circle conversation; every dollar tracked

PILLAR 5 — LEGACY

- Once a quarter: one page on what you want to be known for in ten years — every major decision passes through it
- Family money conversations happen openly; money is a tool, not a secret
- Faith and values anchors get explicit calendar time
- Once a year: a letter to yourself five years out; read last year's the day you write the new one

The quarterly decision review — 60 minutes

Once a quarter, sit down — the athlete plus a parent or the closest advisor — and run four steps. It is the most important hour of the quarter off the field.

1. **Last-quarter audit (15 min).** Deals signed and declined, and what each cost or earned. Which Circle relationships produced. What content moved the brand. What you know now that you did not.
2. **Pillar check (15 min).** Score each pillar 1–5 on how well the *system* is running. The lowest score is the work.
3. **90-day plan (20 min).** The one-to-three things that matter most. Pipeline status. The conversations you have been avoiding — schedule them. The ones not producing — end them.
4. **Legacy alignment (10 min).** Is what you did this quarter aligned with the ten-year identity? If not, was the change deliberate?

The athlete-as-a-business dashboard

Touchdowns matter for tomorrow's game. These ten numbers determine the ten-year outcome.

METRIC	WHY IT MATTERS	FREQUENCY
Total NIL income (gross)	Top of the funnel	Monthly
Income net of taxes + reserves	Real take-home	Monthly
Active deals + pipeline value	Forward visibility	Monthly
Deal acceptance rate	Filter discipline	Quarterly
Average deal size	Leverage trend	Quarterly
Brand alignment score (your judgment)	Drift early-warning	Quarterly
Audience growth + engagement	Marketability proxy	Monthly
Content shipped	Consistency	Weekly
Time invested in Circle relationships	Right people, right investment	Monthly
On-field vs. business hours	Sport stays primary	Weekly

Building optionality

The most underrated discipline in any career is keeping doors open. Most athletes prematurely commit — big offer in front of them, they sign. They mistake the size of the offer for the value of the partnership. Optionality means deciding in ways that protect your future range of choices:

- **Default to shorter terms.** One-year deals let you renegotiate from strength.
- **Default to narrower exclusivity.** Whatever they ask, propose less.
- **Protect future partners.** If you can imagine signing Brand B in 18 months, do not lock yourself out today.
- **Default to invest, not spend.** A depreciating car is the opposite of optionality. An LLC, a brokerage account, the right asset at the right time — those expand what is possible later.
- **Default to relationships, not transactions.** The exec on last year's small deal is the one who calls with next year's big one — if the first one was handled well.

Legacy thinking — the 30-year view

Most athlete decisions run on a 30-day horizon: what does this do for me right now. The athletes who build something lasting decide on a 30-year horizon: what does this do for who I want to be. Legacy is not built at the end of a career — it is a way of deciding throughout it. Whatever your anchor is — for many families it is faith — it has to be specific enough to actually filter decisions. Vague values decide nothing.

Worksheet — the one-page legacy statement

Fill it in. Read it on quarterly review days. Update it once a year.

In 30 years, the people I most want to make proud are: ______________________________

The character traits I want to be known for are: ______________________________

The faith / values anchor of my life is: ______________________________

The kind of family I am building is: ______________________________

The financial position I am building toward is: ______________________________

The impact I want beyond my sport is: ______________________________

If a 19-year-old me read my life today, they would say: ______________________________

PARENT LANE / ATHLETE LANE

Parent or guardian — You own the calendar and the cadence — the quarterly review happens because you scheduled it and protected the hour. Systems rarely die from being wrong; they die from never being scheduled.

Athlete — You own the legacy page and the pillar scores. One page, once a quarter, in your own words — it is the page every other decision gets measured against, and nobody can write it for you.

MODULE 5 TAKEAWAY

You do not rise to the level of your goals — **you fall to the level of your systems.** Five pillars, standing orders, a quarterly review, ten numbers, optionality discipline, and a clear legacy frame. Run it consistently and you become the athlete who looks back in 30 years glad you did.

BONUS 1

The Outreach Playbook

How to find brand partners — without crossing the agent line.

Go Find the Brands

Most athletes wait for brands to find them. The athletes who win at NIL go find the brands — but cold outreach without structure becomes noise, and brands ignore noise. This is the seven-step, Sandler-based sequence we run with our pilot athlete, Connor Barry, alongside his agent.

The caveat comes first: every step here runs with agent supervision. The athlete generates qualified interest; **the agent closes.** No agent yet? The sequence is still useful for relationship-building — but never talk pricing or commit to terms.

The five principles, adapted from Sandler

1. **Upfront contracts.** Set expectations clearly at the start of every conversation.
2. **Pain first.** Don’t pitch — diagnose. Find what the brand is trying to solve before proposing anything.
3. **A fast no beats a slow maybe.** It is okay to hear no; it frees your time for real fits.
4. **No free consulting.** Don’t give away strategy or content concepts in cold messages. Build curiosity.
5. **Agent-first.** Generate interest. Hand off. Always.

The seven-step sequence

STEP 1 — RESEARCH (DAY 0)

Read the brand's recent posts, athlete partners, and active campaigns. Identify 1–3 decision-makers on LinkedIn (titles like *athlete partnerships*, *brand marketing*, *sports marketing* — and if you do not have a LinkedIn account, make one today). Write down one specific, recent, true thing about the brand you can reference. Not "I love your brand."

STEP 2 — LINKEDIN CONNECTION REQUEST (DAY 1)

> *Hi [First Name] — saw [Brand] just signed [recent athlete / launched X]. As a [school] [position] working on a small group of NIL partnerships this year, I'd love to connect and learn how you're thinking about [sport] this season. — [Name]*

STEP 3 — FIRST DM AFTER CONNECTION (DAY 3–5)

> *Hi [First Name] — appreciate you connecting. Quick context: I'm working with my representation team to be intentional about the NIL partnerships I take on this year — we're being selective, looking for 4–5 brands where there's real cultural fit, not just a check. [Brand] keeps coming up in our research because of [specific thing]. I'm not pitching anything. I'd just love 15 minutes to learn what your team is focused on this season, and whether what we're building could fit. If it's not a fit, totally good — we'd both rather know quickly. — [Name], [school] [position]*

STEP 4 — EMAIL FOLLOW-UP (DAY 7, IF NO RESPONSE)

Different inbox, different angle. Confirm inferred email patterns before sending.

STEP 5 — SOFT BUMP (DAY 12, ONLY IF NEEDED)

> *Hi [First Name] — circling back once in case the timing is better this week. Totally fine if [Brand] isn't focused on college NIL right now or I'm not the right fit — a quick yes/no helps me focus on the brands where there's mutual interest. Either way, appreciate the time. — [Name]*

STEP 6 — DISCOVERY CALL (WHEN THEY ENGAGE)

Your job on the call is to diagnose, not pitch. Eight questions:

1. What made [Brand] open to talking with athletes like me — what are you trying to drive this year?
2. When you've worked with college athletes before, what made it work? What didn't?
3. If we did something together, what would have to be true in 6 months for you to call it a win?
4. Who else on your side is involved in deciding partnerships like this?
5. What does your typical timeline and budget structure look like for college NIL?
6. Are there other athletes you're already talking to in this space?
7. What's the worst athlete partnership you've experienced?
8. If we both think there's a fit, what do next steps look like on your side?

> **Never propose pricing on the discovery call.** If they ask your rate: *"My team handles all commercial terms — once we confirm fit on the concept, I'll loop in [Agent Name] to walk through structure."* Then return to discovery. Saying a number on the call costs you leverage every time.

STEP 7 — AGENT HANDOFF (WITHIN 24 HOURS)

Email your agent and the brand contact together. Brief your agent on priority, timeline, budget signal, and decision-makers. You stay the relationship-holder; you step back from commercial terms.

The weekly routine — 90 minutes total

DAY	TIME	WORK
Monday	15 min	Pick 5 brands. Mark as "researching."
Monday	60 min	Research + send 5 connection requests.
Wednesday	30 min	First DMs to new connections. Email follow-ups due.
Friday	30 min	Update statuses. Soft bumps. Brief your agent on live conversations.

> **BONUS 1 TAKEAWAY**
>
> Find brands. Open with curiosity. **Hand every commercial conversation to your agent.** Run the 90-minute weekly routine with discipline and you will have ten or more active conversations within eight weeks.

BONUS 2

Your 30-Day Action Plan

What to do — week by week — starting today.

The First Month, Sequenced

This plan assumes you have read Modules 1–5 and want them in motion this month. Each week has focused tasks. Do not attempt everything in week one — the point is steady, compounding momentum. Split the work using the parent/athlete lanes from each module.

Week 1 — Foundation

- Complete the Module 1 Circle audit together. Name the most urgent gap or conflict.
- Schedule a call with your closest mentor; talk through Module 5.
- Read your school's current NIL policy. Save the compliance officer's contact — both phones.
- Open the separate tax-reserve account. Set the automatic 30% transfer.
- Audit your social: do the bio, headline, and featured posts reflect your brand promise?

Week 2 — Circle + legal

- Identify and contact 2–3 candidate sports/entertainment lawyers in your state. Schedule intro calls.
- If you have an agent: re-read the agreement against Module 2's red-flag list.
- If you have a financial advisor: confirm fiduciary status in writing.
- Put every signed NIL contract in one cloud folder.
- Schedule the CPA call. No CPA? Get one — athlete-specialized preferred.

Week 3 — Brand + outreach

- Write the 3-sentence brand promise. Read it daily.
- Update LinkedIn per Bonus 1. Identify 5 aligned brands and start the tracker.
- Send the first connection requests (agent-supervised if applicable).
- Audit the last 30 days of posts against the brand promise. Archive conflicts.

Week 4 — Operating system

- Run the full quarterly review (Module 5). Sixty minutes, together.
- Write the one-page legacy statement.
- Pick the 5 dashboard metrics you will actually track.
- Put the next quarterly review on the calendar — recurring.
- Choose one commitment from Modules 1–5 to hold for 90 days. Tell your mentor.

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE

Do this 30-day plan. The athletes who put structure in place in their first month see compounding returns for the rest of their careers. **The athletes who "will get to it eventually" never quite do.**

BONUS 3

The Connor Barry Case Study

The pilot athlete — what we built, what we kept off the table, and why.

The Path Nobody Drafts

Connor Barry is a quarterback at Penn State (#17) and the pilot athlete for The Athlete Circle. His story matters for this playbook not because it is extraordinary, but because it is repeatable — and because every framework in this book was run, in real time, alongside it.

Connor grew up in Vienna, Virginia, and captained James Madison High School to a 13–2 season and a state runner-up finish — the most accomplished season in school history, finishing 22–3 as a starter and earning Northern Virginia Football Hall of Fame Player of the Year. He received no FBS scholarship offers. He walked on at Appalachian State, sat behind three quarterbacks, and never appeared in a game.

Most stories end there. Connor transferred to Christopher Newport University, a Division III program, and rebuilt from the ground up: starter as a sophomore, then a junior season in 2025 that produced the first undefeated regular season in school history (10–0), school records in passing efficiency and touchdown passes, and national recognition. In January 2026 — after Penn State hired Matt Campbell and quarterbacks coach Jake Waters reached out — Connor committed and signed. By spring practice he was taking the bulk of the first- and second-team reps, and Campbell was calling him “probably the surprise” of camp.

RECOGNITION

- **Northern Virginia Football Hall of Fame Player of the Year** (2021)
- **Touchdown Club of Richmond Quarterback of the Year in Virginia** (2024)
- **NJAC Offensive Player of the Year** (2025)
- **AFCA Second-Team All-American** (2025)
- **Gagliardi Trophy semifinalist** — the first in CNU football history (2025)

What Connor's Circle looks like today

ROLE	WHO	NOTES
Lawyer	Independent counsel	Engaged for contract review — including his agent contract
Agent	Seasoned agent of record	All commercial conversations route through him. No exceptions.
Financial Advisor	Family-engaged CPA + planner	Tax reserve, LLC structure, long-term plan
Trainer	PSU strength + position staff	School-program-led; private skills coach off-season
Mentor	Family + faith community	Parents, faith leaders, peer athletes

What Connor has said no to — and why

- **Bypassing the agent.** Brands reach out directly constantly. Every one is routed. No exceptions.
- **Quick-close pressure.** Several offers came with "sign by Friday" urgency. None were accepted under it.
- **Brand-voice misalignment.** Some categories pay well and conflict with his faith-and-family identity. Off-limits regardless of price.
- **Prohibited categories.** Alcohol, gambling, sportsbooks — universal pass during eligibility.
- **Verbal commitments.** Nothing that could be construed as binding is said without paper.

What Connor has said yes to — selectively

Disciplined volume management: a small number of high-fit partnerships that compound his brand long-term. Specifics evolve quarterly; the selection filter never changes — faith-and-family brand voice, reasonable term length, narrow category exclusivity, approval rights on content, and morality clauses with objective standards.

The system in practice

Quarterly decision review on the calendar, run with his father. The weekly Bonus 1 outreach routine, agent-supervised. A rolling database of pre-qualified brands shared with his agent. An intentional faith-and-family content calendar. And tax-reserve discipline — every NIL dollar splits across reserve, invest, spend on receipt.

Connor was not a five-star recruit. He is not a Heisman frontrunner. He is a Big Ten quarterback with a clear identity, a structured Circle, and a system that turns each decision into a brick in a 30-year wall. Most athletes at any tier do not operate this way — and the gap between the ones who do and the ones who do not widens every quarter.

> *Performance opens the door. The system is what walks through it.*

What you can borrow: all of it. Adjust the variables — sport, position, conference, hometown, identity, agent — and the structure works the same way. The Athlete Operating System is sport-agnostic and tier-agnostic. **The discipline is the asset.** Career detail current as of April 2026; used with family consent.

BONUS 4

The Family Conversation, Extended

The facilitator's edition — for the parent running the table.

BONUS 4

Running the Table

The free guide introduced the Family Conversation: five questions, thirty minutes, one table, no phones. This is the extended edition — how to *facilitate* it, how to handle the moments where it gets hard, and how to turn a one-time conversation into a quarterly family operating rhythm.

The five questions, with facilitation notes

1. **What are we actually trying to build?** Both answer in writing *before* anyone speaks — it prevents the athlete anchoring on the parent's answer, or the reverse. The answers are usually closer than either expects; where they differ is the agenda for question 5.
2. **Who is already close to us, and why?** List everyone who has offered help in the last year, and what each gets out of it. Facilitation note: the athlete goes first, and nobody reacts until the list is complete. The fastest way to stop hearing the truth is to react to it.
3. **What are we not willing to do for money?** Decide categories, brands, and behaviors now, in the quiet, while it costs nothing. Write the list down — this becomes the values line in every Module 3 filter run.
4. **Who decides what?** Read every Parent lane / Athlete lane box in this playbook out loud and agree to them — or amend them in writing. Ambiguity here is where most family conflict actually lives.
5. **What are we most exposed on right now?** Everyone names one thing. Pick the single one you will fix first, assign it a lane and a date.

When you disagree — the protocol

You will disagree. The usual split: the athlete sees the opportunity, the parent sees the risk. Both are seeing correctly — different time horizons. Three rules resolve most of it:

1. **Lanes rule.** The athlete decides what they want to be known for. The parent decides what gets signed. Neither vetoes the other's lane.
2. **48-hour rule.** Any decision either of you feels pressured on gets 48 hours automatically. Real opportunities survive two days; the ones that do not were never opportunities.
3. **Third-chair rule.** Deadlocked twice on the same decision? Bring it to the mentor — not for a verdict, but for the question neither of you is asking.

Stage variants

- **HS underclassman:** run it annually. The exposure question is mostly social media and who is showing up around the program.
- **HS junior/senior:** quarterly. Recruiting contact makes question 2 the center of gravity.
- **College, pre-NIL:** quarterly, synced to the Module 5 review. Question 3 hardens into the written values line.
- **College, earning:** monthly check-in on lanes and pipeline; full five questions quarterly. Money makes drift fast — cadence is the antidote.

The 90-day cadence

End every conversation by scheduling the next one before anyone leaves the table. A conversation that happens once is a nice evening. A conversation that happens quarterly is a system — and it composes with the Module 5 quarterly review into a single family hour: thirty minutes on the five questions, thirty on the pillars and pipeline.

BONUS 4 TAKEAWAY

The family is the first Circle. **Facilitate, don't dominate:** written answers first, no reacting to the truth, lanes respected, 48 hours on pressure, mentor on deadlock, next date on the calendar before the table clears.

BONUS 5

Quick-Reference Cards

The four pages to print, pin up, and reach for in the moment.

CARD 1 · PRINT ME

The 5-Question NIL Filter

Run every offer through these, **in order**. Stop at the first failure.

1. **Values** — would I want this partnership as the lead line of my profile in ten years?
2. **Commitments** — read the deliverables and exclusivity out loud. Is the real workload acceptable?
3. **Price** — inside the market range for my tier? (Check the current quarterly update.)
4. **Lockouts** — what doors does this close, and what is behind them worth over 12 months?
5. **Structure** — NIL Go report, compliance, entity, tax reserve, lawyer, agent: all ready?

THE ONE SENTENCE THAT BUYS TIME

“Thanks — send it over in writing and I will come back to you within 48 hours.”

CARD 2 · PRINT ME

The 12 Contract Red Flags

Scan every contract for these before it goes to your lawyer. Any hit gets circled and raised.

#	FLAG	TRIGGER LANGUAGE
1	Perpetual rights	“in perpetuity,” “indefinite,” “forever”
2	Unbounded exclusivity	“exclusive worldwide,” “any related category”
3	Subjective morality clause	“sole discretion,” “objectionable conduct”
4	Uncapped indemnification	“indemnify,” “hold harmless”
5	Tied services	their photographer / advisor / manager, required
6	First refusal rights	“right of first refusal / negotiation”
7	No approval rights	silence on content approval
8	Auto-renewal	“shall automatically renew”
9	One-way assignability	assignment without your consent
10	Distant forum	governed and litigated far from home
11	Oversized damages	penalties exceeding deal value
12	Vague deliverables	“reasonable,” “as needed,” “mutually agreed”

CARD 3 · PRINT ME

The 7 Gates Before Signing

Any "no" = stop and resolve. Never sign and hope.

1. Lawyer reviewed and approved
2. Agent signed off (if applicable)
3. 5-question filter passed
4. 12 red flags checked — none present unmodified
5. Compliance notified · NIL Go report filed or planned
6. Entity, bank account, and tax reserve ready
7. Signing from alignment, not pressure

THE FINANCE STANDING ORDER

Every NIL dollar on receipt: 30% tax reserve · 10% long-term investing · the rest budgeted on purpose.

The Scripts

Verbal pressure, any source

> “My team handles all commercial conversations. Can you send the proposed terms in writing? I’ll get on a call with my agent and lawyer to walk through it.”

Under 18

> “I’m not 18. My parents handle all of this. Please send it to them in writing.”

Asked for your rate on a call

> “My team handles all commercial terms — once we confirm fit on the concept, I’ll loop in my agent to walk through structure.”

The four things never said out loud

1. “I’ll wear it on game day.”
2. “I’ll post X times.”
3. “That sounds good — let’s do it.”
4. “I won’t sign with anyone else in the meantime.”

Memorize until boring. Boring is what safe sounds like.

BONUS 6

Your Strategy Call + Quarterly Updates

The strategy call — 15 minutes, included

Every purchaser gets one focused 15-minute strategy session with The Athlete Circle team. Fifteen minutes is enough for exactly one of the three uses below — pick the one where you are most exposed right now, and come with your worksheet already filled in:

1. **Circle audit** — walk your Module 1 worksheet and identify the highest-leverage gap.
2. **Live deal review** — run a real offer through the Module 3 filter together.
3. **Plan pressure-test** — customize the 30-day plan to your stage and sport.

To schedule: email hello@athletecircle.ai with the subject “Strategy Call — [Your Name],” including your sport, school or grade, and which single use fits. A calendar link comes back within 48 hours. Parents are welcome on the call — for athletes under 18, a parent or guardian books and joins.

Quarterly updates — included for 12 months

NIL rules change quarterly now — thresholds move, review standards evolve, state laws shift. Your purchase includes four quarterly updates by email covering rule changes, new clause patterns, and current market rates. No additional cost. No upsells. The updates come from the same place as this playbook: running the system with real athletes in real time.

Contact — hello@athletecircle.ai · athletecircle.ai. Brands seeking to reach our athlete network: partnerships@athletecircle.ai.

CLOSING

The Long Game

There is no shortcut. The athletes who turn talent into a long career, a real financial foundation, and a life they are proud of in 30 years share one thing: they treated their early years not as a sprint to maximize each opportunity, but as the construction of a system. They built a Circle. They ran decisions through frameworks. They protected optionality. They ran the same unglamorous routines every quarter while their peers chased the shiny new offer.

The opposite path is louder, faster, and easier in the short term. The cost shows up later — in deals signed too quickly, money spent before it was understood, relationships that compounded the wrong way, identities shaped by whoever pitched hardest. By the time it is visible, it is structural.

You are holding the alternative — a family holding it together, ideally. Not because this playbook is magic; it is not. But because running these frameworks, with the right Circle, every week, for years, is what separates the two paths.

> *Most athletes plan their week. Few plan their decade. None of those few are accidents.*

Now do the work.

Disclaimer

This playbook is educational. It is not legal advice, financial advice, or representation. The frameworks help you ask better questions and identify risk earlier — they do not replace a licensed attorney, a registered financial advisor, or a properly vetted agent. Before signing any agreement, get qualified professional review.

Written for student athletes and the parents and guardians who guide them. Athletes under 18 should use this material with a parent or guardian; every decision requiring a signature is an adult decision. Purchases and email signups are for adults only.

Regulatory references, market rates, and enforcement patterns reflect conditions as of July 2026 and are subject to change — the quarterly update is the maintenance layer. Connor Barry's story and likeness are used with family consent; career detail current as of April 2026.

Version history

VERSION	DATE	CHANGES
1.0	May, 2026	Initial release. 5 modules + 4 bonuses.
2.0	July, 2026	Full brand design. Module 3 rewritten for the post-House 2026 NIL landscape (revenue sharing, CSC, NIL Go). Connor Barry case study updated through spring 2026. Added parent/athlete lanes, The Family Conversation Extended, Quick-Reference Cards, and the Where You Are stage map. Strategy call standardized at 15 minutes. Buyer watermark footer added.